

From Kannauj to Bairati

*The journey and calling of the Barkhora Pandeys,
told with the evidence behind every claim*

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Kashyap gotra · Bairati, Chaukhutiya tehsil, Almora, Uttarakhand · September 2026

BEFORE YOU READ

How this history is written

Family histories are easily blurred by retelling. So this article makes no claim it cannot support. Every statement carries a label saying how strong the evidence behind it is, and the open questions are set out plainly at the end, so the next generation knows exactly where to look.

EVIDENCE LABEL	WHAT IT MEANS
DOCUMENTED	Checked against a source that can be read today (a census, a published reference, a standard text).
RECORDED TRADITION	Written down in local histories of Kumaon, which do not cite an original record.
FAMILY RECORD	Held in the family's own genealogy, handed down within the family.
NOT YET VERIFIED	Suggested somewhere, but no source has yet been found for it.

A NOTE ON THE NAME

Older books and local histories write the surname as **Pande** (पांडे); the family writes it **Pandey** (पाण्डेय). They are the same surname. This article uses Pandey throughout, keeping “Pande” only where it is part of an author's own name, such as the historian Badri Datt Pande.

AT A GLANCE

Gotra	Kashyap (pravara: Kashyapa · Avatsara · Naidhruva)	FAMILY RECORD
Lineage explored	The Kashyap-gotra “Barkhora” Pandeys of Kumaon	RECORDED TRADITION
Its recorded origin	Kannauj, in present-day Uttar Pradesh	RECORDED TRADITION
Ancestral village	Bairati, Chaukhutiya tehsil, Almora district, Uttarakhand (PIN 263653, post office Dwarahat)	DOCUMENTED
Bairati today	314.75 hectares, 763 people in 171 families (Census 2011), with its own gram panchayat	DOCUMENTED
Family genealogy	19 generations, beginning with Sukhdev and his sons Gunankar and Shubhankar	FAMILY RECORD

CONTENTS

- I. The wider story: how learned families came to the hills
- II. The journey: from Kannauj to Bairati
- III. The calling: priests to the kings of Kumaon
- IV. Deep roots: Kannauj and the Kashyap gotra
- V. Our family line
- VI. Open questions, and how we will answer them



An imagined procession of ancestors: an artistic illustration, not a likeness of real people.

The Kumaon hills look isolated, but their families were not. Over many centuries, scholars, administrators and priests came up from the plains of northern India and made the hills their home.

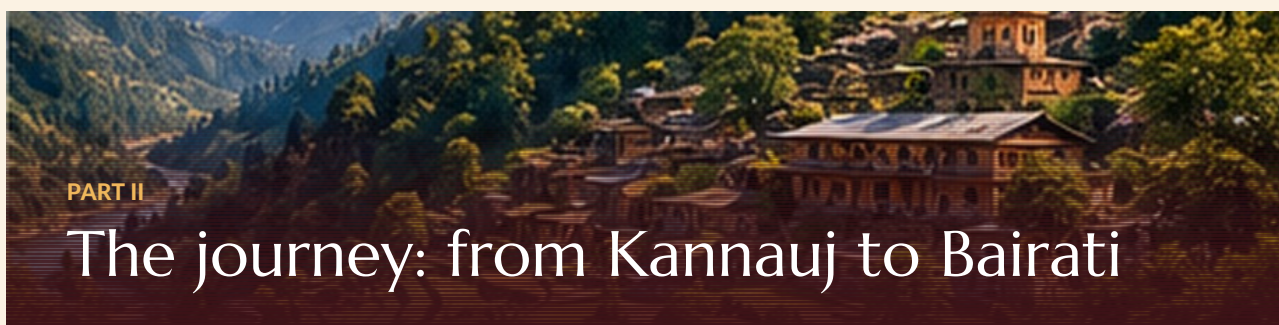
Kumaon is the eastern half of today's Uttarakhand. For several centuries it was ruled by the **Chand dynasty**, a line of Hindu kings who governed first from Champawat and, from the 1560s, from Almora, until their kingdom fell in 1790. **DOCUMENTED**

Regional histories describe how the Chand kings invited learned Brahmins from the plains to serve their courts and temples. The classic account of this period is Pandit Badri Datt Pande's *Kumaon ka Itihas* ("History of Kumaon"), published in Almora in 1937. **RECORDED TRADITION**

These families came from different parts of India. The Kafal Tree account of Kumaon's Brahmin lineages records, for example, that the **Pants** came from the southern Konkan coast of Maharashtra with their ancestor Jaydev Pant, while other Brahmin families came from Prayag and from Kannauj. **RECORDED TRADITION**

THE LINEAGE THIS ARTICLE EXPLORES

This article explores the Kashyap-gotra Barkhora Pandeys, who are recorded as coming from **Kannauj**, a city in today's Uttar Pradesh. Theirs is one of the many journeys that brought learned families from the plains into the hills at the invitation of hill rulers.



The journey: from Kannauj to Bairati

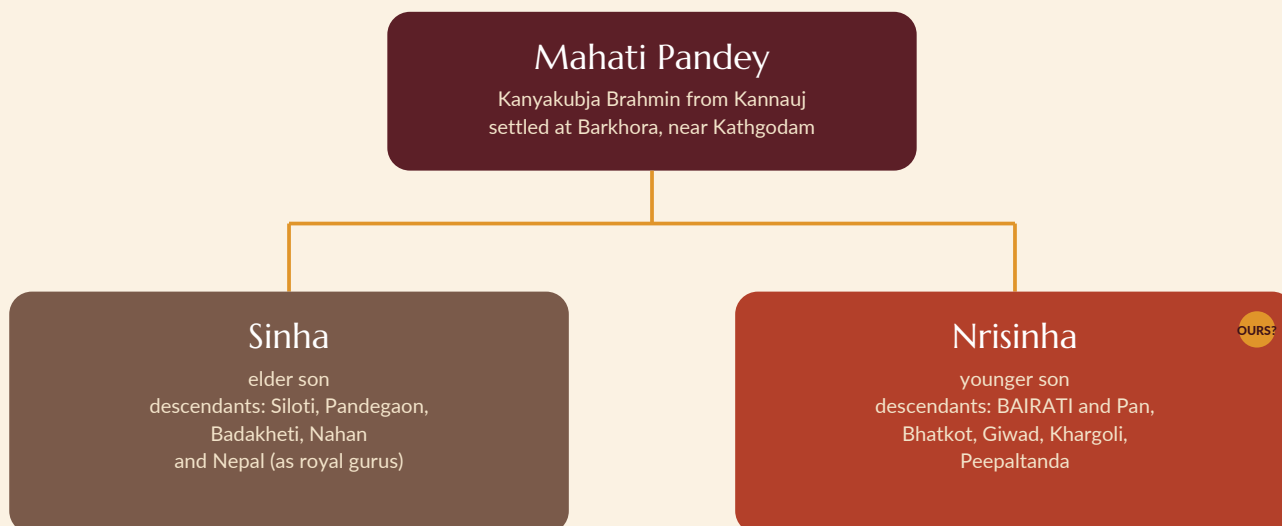
Three separate written accounts of Kumaon's Brahmin lineages tell the same story about the Kashyap-gotra Pandeys, and all three connect it to Bairati.

The founder of the lineage was **Mahati Pandey** (written Mahati or Mahani Pande in the sources), a Kanyakubja Brahmin, that is, of a Brahmin community tracing its descent from Kannauj. He came to the hills with his two sons, **Sinha** and **Nrisinha**, and settled at **Barkhora** (also written Batokhari), near Kathgodam. **RECORDED TRADITION**

Kathgodam today is a town in Nainital district at the foot of the Kumaon hills, the last railway station before the hills, next to Haldwani. The exact location of Barkhora itself has not yet been identified.

When did Mahati come? None of the three accounts gives a year or names the king. A late-1500s or early-1600s date has been suggested, around the time the Chand kings moved their capital to Almora, but no source for it has been found. **NOT YET VERIFIED**

The family then divided. Sinha's descendants spread to Siloti, Pandegaon, Badakheti and Nahan, and into Nepal. **Nrisinha's descendants settled in Bairati**, Bhatkot, Giwad, Khargoli and Peepaltanda. **RECORDED TRADITION** *These villages are named as they appear in the accounts; apart from Bairati and Pan, their present-day locations are still to be identified.*



EXPLORING THE CONNECTION

Why these sources are worth exploring

Several details in these accounts point towards our own village and family, which makes them a promising place to begin the search:

- **The neighbouring village is named too.** Kafal Tree's article *Kumaon ke Brahmanon ka Itihas* ("History of Kumaon's Brahmins", 28 August 2023) states: "बेडती पान में नृसिंह की सन्तान है", meaning "in Bedti–Pan are the descendants of Nrisinha". Pan is the village immediately beside Bairati on NH 109, the Dwarahat–Chaukhutia road. (Dwarahat is a town, and Chaukhutia a tehsil or sub-district, of Almora district.) **RECORDED TRADITION**
- **The gotra matches.** Our family is Kashyap gotra, the gotra these accounts give for the Barkhora Pandeys, and the only Pandey lineage they connect to Bairati. **FAMILY RECORD**

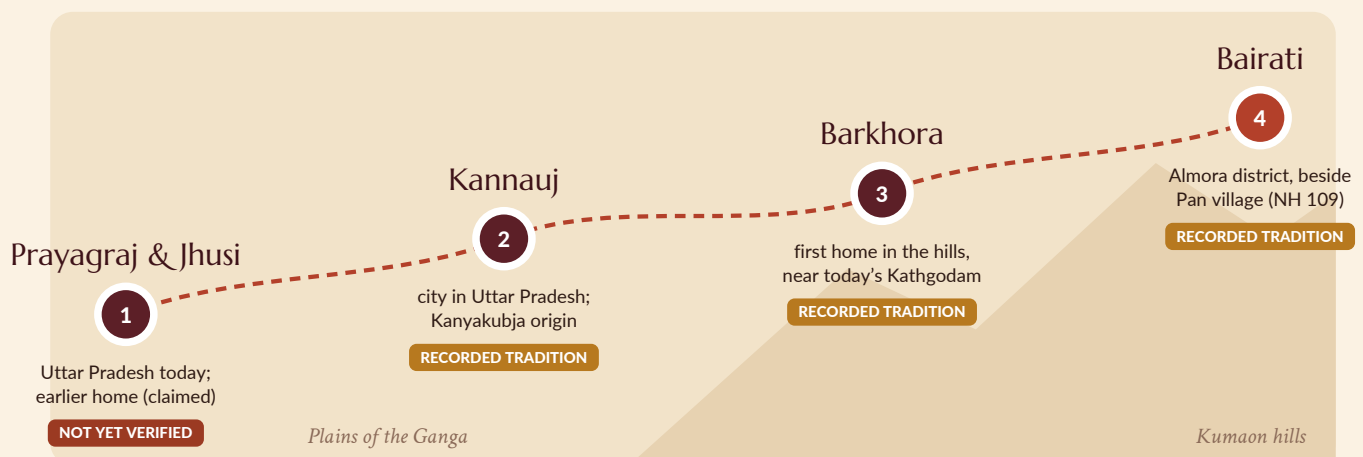
WHAT IS STILL TO BE FOUND

The lineage accounts stop at Nrisinha and do not name his descendants, and our family genealogy begins with Sukhdev. No record yet joins the two. Whether our family belongs to Nrisinha's line therefore remains an open question, and exploring it is one purpose of this research.

THE JOURNEY

From the plains to Bairati

Pieced together from the accounts above, the lineage's journey climbs from the plains of the Ganga to the Kumaon hills. Each stop is labelled with the strength of its evidence.





A journey across rivers, plains and mountains: an artistic illustration.

The accounts do not only say where this lineage came from. They also say why it was welcomed, and what work it was given.

What the sources record

- **Royal priests.** The king made Mahati's family his priests. **RECORDED TRADITION**
- **A village as a jagir.** The king granted them the village of Barkhora as a *jagir*, a grant of land and its income given in return for service. This is how the lineage came to be called the Barkhora Pandeys. **RECORDED TRADITION**
- **Royal gurus in Nepal.** Sinha's branch is said to have served as royal gurus (*rajgurus*) in Nepal. **RECORDED TRADITION**

What that work involved

In the Hindu kingdoms of medieval India, a royal priest (*purohit*) was one of the most trusted figures at court. Such a priest typically:

- performed the religious ceremonies of the royal household, including the life-cycle rites (*sanskaras*) such as naming, the sacred thread ceremony and marriage;
- led worship at festivals and in temples under royal patronage, and fixed auspicious times for ceremonies from the Panchang, the Hindu calendar;
- kept and taught the Sanskrit learning these duties required, passing it from one generation of the family to the next.

A family of Kanyakubja Brahmins was well placed for this role. For centuries Kannauj had been one of the great centres of Sanskrit and Vedic learning in northern India, and rulers far beyond it invited its scholars to their courts. **DOCUMENTED**

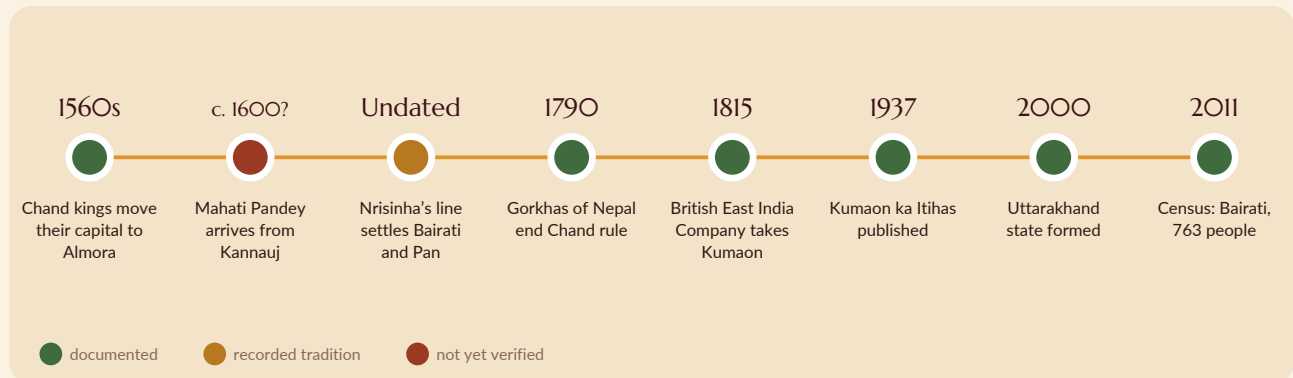
WHAT THIS DOES AND DOESN'T TELL US

The sources describe the calling of the lineage as a whole: priests to the Chand kings, and royal gurus in Nepal. They do not say what work later generations in Bairati did. That, like the names between Nrisinha and Sukhdev, is a question for the records described in Part VI.

KEY DATES

A timeline of the story

Some dates in this history are firm; others are estimates, or undated. The colour of each point shows which is which.



WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED	EVIDENCE
1560s	The Chand kings move their capital from Champawat to Almora.	DOCUMENTED
c. late 1500s or early 1600s (suggested)	Mahati Pandey arrives from Kannauj and settles at Barkhora near Kathgodam. No source found gives a year or names the king.	NOT YET VERIFIED
Not yet dated	Nrisinha's descendants establish themselves in Bairati and Pan.	RECORDED TRADITION
1790	The Gorkhas, the army of the Gorkha kingdom of Nepal, conquer Kumaon and end Chand rule.	DOCUMENTED
1815	After the Anglo-Nepalese War, the British East India Company takes Kumaon; it later passes to the British Crown.	DOCUMENTED
1937	Badri Datt Pande publishes <i>Kumaon ka Itihas</i> in Almora.	DOCUMENTED
2000	Uttarakhand is formed as a separate state from Uttar Pradesh.	DOCUMENTED
2011	The Census records Bairati with 763 people in 171 families.	DOCUMENTED

The hills the lineage came to were ruled by the Chand kings from Almora. That world ended with the Gorkha conquest of 1790, and British rule followed in 1815. Whatever service the lineage gave at the Chand court would have changed with them.



Sage Kashyapa: an artistic illustration.

The lineage explored here traces its roots to Kannauj, and our family's own gotra reaches back to one of the oldest names in the Vedic tradition.

Kannauj

Kannauj is today a city and district in Uttar Pradesh, near the Ganga. Its ancient name, Kanyakubja, gives the Kanyakubja Brahmins their name. **DOCUMENTED**

Prayagraj and Jhusi

Some have suggested that before Kannauj the lineage's ancestors lived around Prayagraj (called Allahabad until 2018) and Jhusi, a town on the opposite bank of the Ganga known in ancient times as Pratishtanpur. No source for this has been found. **NOT YET VERIFIED**

The Kashyap gotra

A gotra traces a family's descent in the male line to a Vedic sage. Ours is Kashyap, after the sage Kashyapa, one of the Saptarishis (the seven great sages). Each gotra has a fixed set of *pravara* sages, recited at ceremonies:

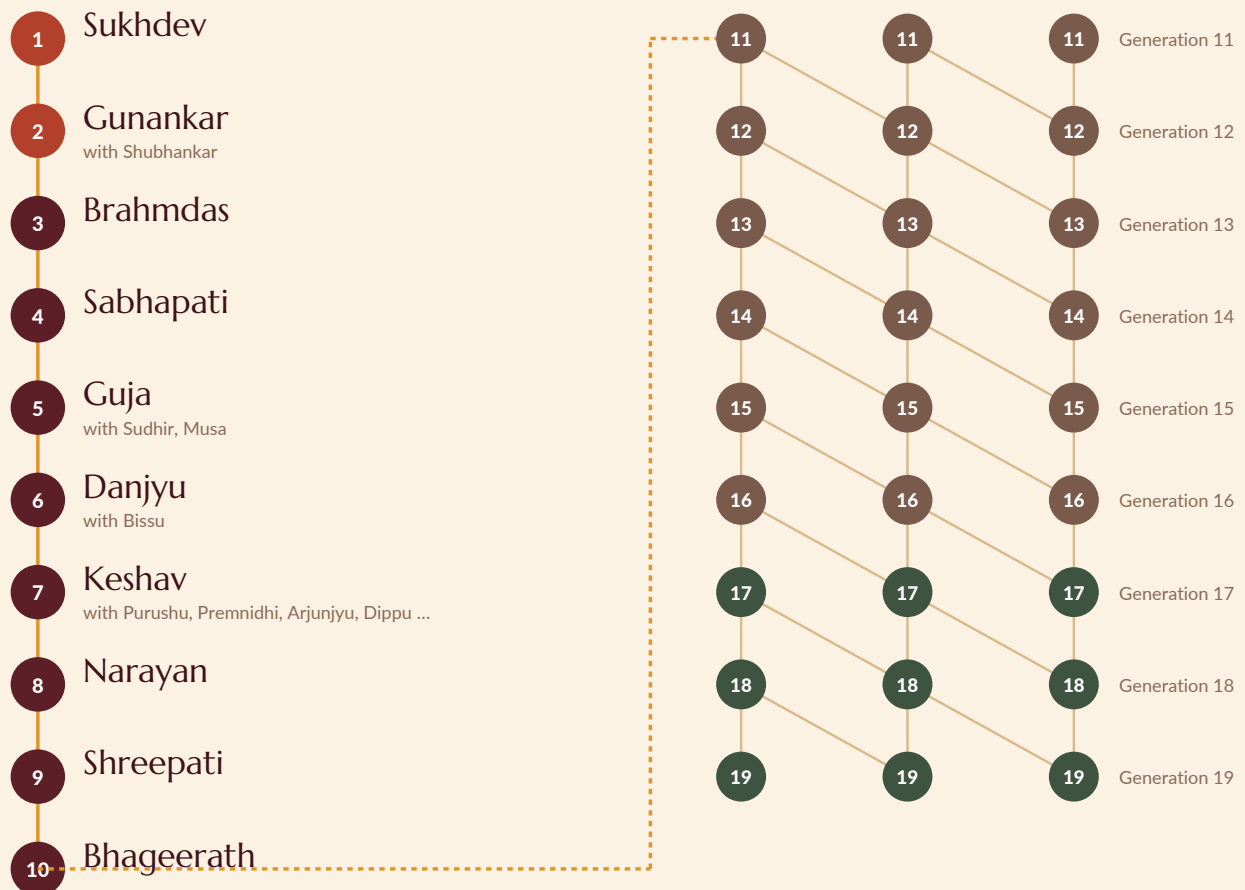
OUR GOTRA	DETAIL	EVIDENCE
Gotra	Kashyap	FAMILY RECORD
Pravara	Kashyapa · Avatsara · Naidhruva (the standard three-sage pravara of the Kashyap gotra)	DOCUMENTED
Veda and shakha	Shukla Yajurveda, Madhyandina shakha has been suggested; to be confirmed with the family priest	NOT YET VERIFIED

"A gotra is a family's oldest address: not a place, but a line of teachers."

PART V

Our family line

The family genealogy records 19 generations. The first ten, from Sukhdev to Bhageerath, form a single line and are shown here by name, with brothers where recorded. From the eleventh generation the family branches into many parallel lines, so those generations are shown by number; every branch is recorded on the family tree website. **FAMILY RECORD**



From generation 11 the family branches into many parallel lines.

Maroon: the single line · brown: the branching generations · green: generations within living memory

ABOUT DATES

The dates written in the family genealogy are not reliable, so none are used here. The early generations clearly lived several centuries ago; finding out when, and whether they connect to Nrisinha's line, is one of the first research tasks.

THE EVIDENCE

What the sources say, in one place

CLAIM	SOURCE	STATUS
Mahati Pandey came from Kannauj with sons Sinha and Nrisinha, and settled at Barkhora near Kathgodam	Kafal Tree (2023); kumauni.in (2019); himalayilog.com	RECORDED TRADITION
The king made the family his priests and granted Barkhora village as a jagir	Kafal Tree (2023); kumauni.in (2019); himalayilog.com	RECORDED TRADITION
Nrisinha's descendants live in Bedti–Pan (Bairati and Pan)	Kafal Tree (2023): “Bedti–Pan”; kumauni.in and himalayilog.com: Bairati	RECORDED TRADITION
Sinha's descendants served as royal gurus in Nepal	kumauni.in (2019); himalayilog.com	RECORDED TRADITION
Our family is Kashyap gotra, and its genealogy begins with Sukhdev and his sons Gunankar and Shubhankar	The family genealogy	FAMILY RECORD
Bairati: 314.75 ha, 763 people in 171 families	Census of India 2011	DOCUMENTED
The date of Mahati's arrival	No source found	NOT YET VERIFIED
The generations between Nrisinha and Sukhdev	No source found	NOT YET VERIFIED

The accounts behind the lineage story were written down relatively recently and do not name their original records. Records of that kind are rarely online; they sit in record rooms and in the ledgers of pilgrimage priests. The next part shows where to look.

PART VI

Open questions, and how we will answer them

Three questions stand at the heart of this history:

1 Does our genealogy join Nrisinha's line?

The shared gotra and village make this worth exploring; only a record naming the generations between Nrisinha and Sukhdev could settle it.

2 When did Mahati Pandey come to the hills, and which king received him?

This would anchor the whole story in time.

3 Which ancestor first held land in Bairati?

The answer tells us when the family's story in the village began.

Where the answers are kept

SOURCE	WHAT IT CAN SETTLE	HOW TO ACCESS IT
Pilgrimage priests' registers (bahi), Haridwar	Generations of names with the village recorded, possibly reaching back to the link with Nrisinha	Find the family's hereditary panda (pilgrimage priest) at Haridwar. FamilySearch publishes a guide to these records.
Land records (khatauni, shajra) and British settlement records	Who held which fields in Bairati, and how the land was divided over time	Tehsil and district record rooms in Chaukhutiya and Almora, especially records from about 1830 to 1890; the Uttarakhand State Archives
Kumaon ka Itihas (1937)	Whether the book names Mahati, Nrisinha or Bairati, and gives a date or a king	Free on the Internet Archive and Kumaoni Archives. Read the chapter on Kumaon's Brahmin lineages.
E. T. Atkinson, The Himalayan Gazetteer	Whether the 1880s British survey of Kumaon's castes lists the Barkhora Pandeys	Online at the Internet Archive.
Family priest and elders	Handwritten genealogies (vanshawali), remembered stories, the family's Veda and rituals	Record conversations with the eldest members. Each memory can be added to the website.

HELP WRITE THE NEXT CHAPTER

If you hold a document, a photograph, a land paper, or simply a story your grandparents told, it belongs in this history. Publish it as an article on the **Articles** page of the family website, where every family member can contribute to this research. Every piece of evidence moves a claim a step closer to "documented".

SOURCES

Sources consulted

- Kafal Tree, *Kumaon ke Brahmanon ka Itihas* ("History of Kumaon's Brahmins"), 28 August 2023: kafaltree.com/kumaoni-brahman-history/. Describes the Kashyap-gotra Barkhora Pandeys, places Nrisinha's descendants in "Bedti-Pan", and records the Konkan origin of the Pante.
- kumauni.in, "Kumauni Pandey history" (2019): kumauni.in/2019/12/Kumauni-Pandey-history.html. Lists Bairati among the villages of the Kashyap-gotra Pandeys.
- himalayilog.com, article on the Pandey lineages of Kumaon. Places Nrisinha's descendants in Bairati, Bhatkot, Giwad, Khargoli and Peepaltanda.
- Badri Datt Pande, *Kumaon ka Itihas*, Shri Almora Book Depot, Almora, 1937. Online at the Internet Archive and Kumauni Archives.
- E. T. Atkinson, *The Himalayan Gazetteer*, 3 volumes, 1882–1886.
- Census of India 2011, village data for Bairati, Chaukhutiya tehsil, Almora district.
- Sahajanand Saraswati, *Brahmarshi Vansh Vistar* (via Gadya Kosh), on gotras and their pravaras.
- The Pandey family genealogy, maintained on the family website.

AN ONGOING WORK

This article is part of ongoing research into the Pandeys of Bairati. It is published as a first step, and it invites further exploration, records and proofs from every branch of the family. Corrections and new evidence are welcome, and later articles will build on what they reveal.